

You Can Walk in it Beloved.

Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?
Thou art more lovely and more temperate:
Rough winds do shake the darling buds of May,
And summer's lease hath all too short a date:
Sometime too hot the eye of heaven shines,
And every fair from fair sometime declines,
By chance, or nature's changing course untrimmed:
But thy eternal summer shall not fade,
Nor lose possession of that fair thou ow'st,
Nor shall death brag thou wander'st in his shade,
When in eternal lines to time thou grow'st,
 So long as men can breathe, or eyes can see,
 So long lives this, and this gives life to thee.

-Sonnet 18- W. Shakespeare

“The fleeting nature of beauty and life has long been tempered by poetry’s power to grant lasting remembrance to the Beloved. Yet, the vow of unconditional love—promising freedom from all restraints—becomes strained by the restless turmoil of daily struggles, where conditions are imposed upon what should remain boundless. Vanity of vanities, says the heart of man, for beauty withers as the grass and the flower fades in its season. Yet the word set down endures, and poetry becomes as a psalm, raising the Beloved above decay, so that their remembrance is as incense before the throne, unconsumed by time. And though the vow of love is an everlasting covenant, the flesh wars against the spirit. Daily trials creep upon the soul, binding with cords of fear and doubt, and the heart is tempted to lay conditions upon that which was given without measure. But un beholden to the restraints of man, love stands as a steadfast rock, unshaken though the waves roar. For perfect love casts out torment, and the Beloved who dwells in it tastes of immortality, even as the world fades away.” – Nathaniel Nevedal

Dedication

To the sons who have longed for a fathers love.

To the fathers who longed for the children they lost.

To the hearts of men which have be mocked by the Devil's hate.

*“Arise, you sleeper! Rise up from your coffin
and the Anointed One will shine his light into you!”*

-Ephesians 5:14 (TPT)

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Introduction

Men are called to walk in strength—but too often, that strength is tangled with wounds, silence, and cycles of regret handed down through generations. Many have learned love must be earned, respect must be fought for, and mistakes must bring punishment or shame. These lessons, though deeply ingrained, run contrary to the design of God, who created men to love and to lead as image bearers: men who reflect His character not in weakness or fear, but in boldness and compassion.

This journey will not be easy. It will demand courage: the courage to confront the ways conditional love, regret, and shame have shaped your heart and relationships. It will require honesty: facing the regrets you have buried, recognizing the patterns that keep you trapped, and breaking the chains that the enemy has forged in your mind. It will ask you to step into uncomfortable truth: that much of what you have learned about strength, love, and maturity must be unlearned, surrendered, and transformed.

But you are not meant to walk alone or remain shackled by the counterfeit love of the past. Christ calls every man to rise, to leave behind the “spiral” of shame and self-condemnation, and to enter the path of restoration, forgiveness, and unconditional love. This workbook is an invitation—a challenge for those who are tired of simply surviving, and ready to become builders of trust, bearers of grace, and sons who walk in the freedom purchased for them by God.

Here, you will be asked problematic questions. You will be prompted to reflect honestly, to pray deeply, to confess and to act. This is not for the faint of heart. But if you are willing—willing to confront your old regrets, your conditioned tendencies, and face your fears head-on—you will discover the strength only found in God’s love: a love that is steadfast, transformative, and enduring.

The challenge is clear: No longer settle for the cycle of shame, regret, and conditional love. Accept the call to walk as God’s Beloved—free, restored, and empowered to love without condition. It is time to lead, to forgive, to break old patterns, and to help others do the same.

This is the journey. Step forward, brother. You can walk in it, Beloved son of God.

Unconditional love vs Conditional Love

In the poetry of W. Shakespeare, you can feel the beauty of God's creation, His gift of the transience of life, and the miracle promises within eternity. William leans into God's Beloved as being more lovely and enduring than any summer day. Expanding further through claims that while natural beauty fades, the youth's beauty will live forever within the words of the one who dares allow his heart to express such words within themselves and believes. He recognizes that everything in nature, including human beauty, is fleeting.

"Charm is deceptive, and beauty is fleeting; but a woman who fears the LORD is to be praised." – Psalm 31:30

This verse explicitly states that outward beauty does not last, emphasizing the enduring value of godly character over appearance.

"The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God stands forever."
– Isaiah 40:8

This passage is a classic biblical metaphor highlighting the transience of earthly beauty and life, contrasted with the enduring nature of God's word. As above, not only are beauty and life fleeting, but God's word is everlasting, likened to poetry and remembrance that outlast decay.

"For you formed my inmost being; you knit me together in my mother's womb. I praise you, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made." – Psalm 139:13-14

The Psalmist above reflects the intimacy of God's knowledge and remembrance of His beloved, paralleling poetry's power to raise the beloved above corrosion. God not only through His word but through His child's own lips echoes remembrance of His word and the everlasting endurance of the authority within it even with the conflict of our flesh and spirit.

"But I see another law at work in me, waging war against the law of my mind and making me a prisoner of the law of sin at work within me." – Romans 7:23

Paul furthers this advance as he describes the inner struggle between flesh and spirit, echoed in your reference to the flesh warring against the spirit.

"For the flesh desires what is contrary to the Spirit, and the Spirit what is contrary to the flesh." – Galatians 5:17

This famously articulates the daily spiritual conflict of feeling conditional love but knowing that unconditional love is imprinted within our DNA as our source of freedom from the flesh and the restraint in which it binds us daily through our own thoughts as well as others.

For we are to be steadfast in love as sons of God as not only as image barriers but also within our own understanding of God's love for us as His Beloved through the freedom of love.

"Love bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things. Love never fails." – 1 Corinthians 13:7-8

Love, conceived as enduring and immovable, directly parallels your "steadfast rock, unshaken though the waves roar." Time over time it is expressed that as sons of God we are to be persistent in being alert and sober minded.

"Be alert and of sober mind. Your enemy the devil prowls around like a roaring lion looking for someone to devour." 1 Peter 5:8

Peter of all men experiences such torment within himself to even give conditional love to our Lord during His most trying times. We see this within scripture of John 21:15-25.

When they had finished eating, Jesus said to Simon Peter,

"Simon son of John, do you love me more than these?"

"Yes, Lord," he said, "you know that I love you."

Jesus said, "Feed my lambs."

Again Jesus said, "Simon son of John, do you love me?"

He answered, "Yes, Lord, you know that I love you."

Jesus said, "Take care of my sheep."

The third time he said to him, "Simon son of John, do you love me?"

Peter was hurt because Jesus asked him the third time,

"Do you love me?"

He said, "Lord, you know all things; you know that I love you."

Jesus said, "Feed my sheep. Very truly I tell you, when you were younger you dressed yourself and went where you wanted; but when you are old you will stretch out your hands, and someone else will dress you and lead you where you do not want to go." Jesus said this to indicate the kind of death by which Peter would glorify God. Then he said to him, "Follow me!"

Our Lord, our God leans into Simon son of John, who He renamed Peter, by first asking him from unconditional love...

"Simon son of John, do you love me more than these?"

The translation in which God references love here is from agape love – Godly love or unconditional love. He directly uses Peter’s earthly name of his father versus using his God given name Peter. The Lord in this passage asks him three times and every time Peter’s reply was through brotherly love versus Godly love. He answered Jesus back in what is translated as *phileō*. This brotherly love comes from a form of conditional love. For *phileō* was returned to Jesus from Peter, but Jesus expressed *agapaō* which was unconditional love. Many scholars have been curious about this passage due to the Lord calling out Peter, as Simon instead.

My opinion within this teaching was the Lord was testing Peter’s heart at the time if Peter understood that his earthly love will always be conditional and that only by borrowing love from the Holy Spirit could Peter manifest the truth within him, that truth of his original design as being Beloved. Time over time, Jesus calls him to answer him in the love he has for Jesus. Each time he expresses his love in conditional love, *phileō*. The Lord knew this truth, even when Peter replies and questions Jesus about his love for him. My belief is, this why Jesus asked the third time if Simon loved him. In this moment Jesus replied to Simon from *phileō* and not from *agapaō*, he mirrored Simon’s only known love at the time with the question. Jesus asked him twice in *agapaō*, unconditionally, to address the flesh in Simon. Knowing that Simon was only taught conditional love from his own father and loved ones. Furthering this truth in his last time the Lord asks, knowing that throughout the generations of Simon his father’s, fathers only knew how to address another in conditional love, brotherly love, *phileō*. Moreover, knowing that Simon would one day claim his beloved name Peter, renewing himself from conditional love and transforming himself into his God given birthright and image as unconditional love.

Jesus said, “Feed my sheep. Very truly I tell you, when you were younger you dressed yourself and went where you wanted; but when you are old you will stretch out your hands, and someone else will dress you and lead you where you do not want to go.” Jesus said this to indicate the kind of death by which Peter would glorify God. Then he said to him, “Follow me!”

When the teaching Jesus knew men were not yet able to understand in their hearts that they are to walk in unconditional love and set aside their youthful, as well as generational earthly father’s teaching about, *phileō – conditional love* and instead come into a new creation being clothed by another in *agapaō – unconditional love*. A creature in which does not bare the image of conditional love like Simon’s original father seeded generation after generation but instead stand as a lampstand of unconditional love in His heavenly Father, our Lord, our God Jesus Christ... “Follow me!”

We can further deepen this understanding and difference between conditional and unconditional by staying in the certainty that unconditional love is freedom and conditional love comes from a cost.

"There is no fear in love. But perfect love drives out fear, because fear has to do with punishment." – 1 John 4:18

The Lord teaches us here that the cost of conditional love seeds punishment and fear. An important understanding within this scripture by John is the use of "drives out" or "cast" in other translations. This same word references the meaning of dissolution or removing from oneself. John is addressing the importance that reading is to deliver themselves from fear by casting out anything within their love that causes punishment or comes from the cost of a condition to receive or give love to oneself or another individual. Comparing back to John 21, we can see that the Lord was aware that men solely knew conditional love and that He must help them walk in a different mind and path. Break away the generational strongholds of men's youth and upbringing in contrast to develop sons of God, true image barriers of His word. In doing so His commands address our immorality through love and faithfulness.

"I am the resurrection and the life. The one who believes in me will live, even though they die." – John 11:25-26

This verse associate's faith and love with the promise of immortality, even as "the world fades away." Peter, being the head of Christ's church, further deepens his understanding of conditional love and preaches the difference within himself as he turns away from the bondage of expressing conditional love and leans into unconditional love.

"Your beauty should not come from outward adornment, such as elaborate hairstyles and the wearing of gold jewelry or fine clothes. Rather, it should be that of your inner self, the unfading beauty of a gentle and quiet spirit, which is of great worth in God's sight." – 1 Peter 3:3-4

Peter expresses his new understanding of how he loves by emphasizing the "unfading beauty of a gentle and quiet spirit, which is of great worth in God's sight," underscoring the immortality granted to those who embody true spiritual love and virtue. This outward expression of conditional love is for others to accept an individual for who they are. Teaching that these conditions for love punish and condemn the hearts of those who use outer appearances to be loved and respected. We can notice Peter here leaning into the fear of God's people dividing their love based on the conditions of outward appearance versus the truth of God's love which is the inner man. Here is a list of scriptures to consider during this journey to find unconditional love within yourself as well as exhibit this unto others.

"A new command I give you: Love one another. As I have loved you, so you must love one another." – John 13:34

This verse is part of Jesus' farewell discourse where He commands His disciples to love each other with the same selfless, sacrificial love that He has shown them. This love serves as the defining mark of His followers and is considered "new" because Jesus sets His own

example as the standard for how they should love, surpassing the Old Testament teaching of loving one's neighbor.

"Beloved, since God so loved us, we also ought to love one another. No one has ever seen God; but if we love one another, God lives in us and his love is made complete in us." – 1 John 4:11-12

These verses emphasize that because God's love for us is so great and unconditional, we are called to demonstrate that same love to one another. Although no one has physically seen God, His presence is manifest in us when we love each other, and through this love, God's love is perfected or fulfilled within us.

"For this is the message you have heard from the beginning: We should love one another." – 1 John 3:11

This verse emphasizes the foundational Christian message—to love one another—which has been taught from the very beginning of the gospel. It recalls Jesus' command in John 13:34 to love as He loved and serves as a key ethical principle throughout the New Testament.

"Let no debt remain outstanding, except the continuing debt to love one another, for whoever loves others has fulfilled the law." – Romans 13:8

This verse teaches that while believers should strive to keep their financial and social obligations clear, the one perpetual "debt" that remains is the obligation to love others continually. By loving others, a person fulfills the entire moral law since love encompasses and motivates all righteous behavior.

"And now, dear lady, I am not writing you a new command but one we have had from the beginning. I ask that we love one another." – 2 John 1:5

This verse highlights that the command to love one another is not a new instruction but a foundational teaching from the beginning of the Christian faith. It is a reminder and an earnest request to remain faithful to this enduring command of love. It was uncommon for men in those days to tutor women. This is another understanding that not only are we men called to be unconditionally loving towards others but both God's creation, which are made in his image both women and men are called unto this original command, which we believe is new but has been the calling since the beginning.

"By this everyone will know that you are my disciples, if you love one another." – John 13:35

This verse powerfully emphasizes that the defining mark of Jesus' followers is the love they show one another. It is through this love that the world can recognize and distinguish true

discipleship. This command is part of Jesus' final instructions to His disciples, highlighting love as the ultimate testimony of faith. We "must" walk in His discipleship so that we carry the image of our Father in heaven as His son. These are key characteristics of discipleship within and under Jesus Christ:

- **Following** Jesus wholeheartedly and putting Him first in life
- **Being** transformed by His Spirit to reflect His character
- **Obedying** His commands and teachings in daily living
- **Committing** to the mission of spreading the gospel within our hearts
- **Abiding** in Christ through prayer, study, and community with other believers

You are an image bearer...

An "image bearer" refers to a person who is made in the "image of God" (Imago Dei), a theological concept meaning that humans reflect certain characteristics of God. This statement does not suggest that individuals possess divinity; rather, it indicates that they are intended to serve as representatives of God on earth in various capacities. Being an image bearer means having unique qualities that reflect God's nature, such as rationality, morality, creativity, relationship capacity, and dominion over creation. This also establishes human dignity and worth, as each person carries God's imprint. The image includes:

- **Substantive aspect:** What humans inherently are in their nature, both physical and spiritual.
- **Relational aspect:** How humans experience and express relationships, reflecting God's relational nature.
- **Functional aspect:** How humans act to represent God's authority and stewardship over creation.

Jesus Christ is the perfect image bearer, revealing God fully through His life and work. Believers are called to live as God's image bearers by reflecting His character and love in the world.

*"Be completely humble and gentle; be patient, bearing with one another in love."
– Ephesians 4:2*

God teaches that living a life worthy of the Christian calling involves embodying these four qualities: **humility, gentleness, patience, and loving forbearance toward others**. Humility reminds believers to avoid pride, gentleness helps to maintain peace, patience allows endurance through difficulties and bearing with one another in love fosters unity and mutual support within the community of faith.

You are His Beloved, valued, respected, broken, and divided in flesh and spirit... However, we are designed to walk in unconditional love, agape love. The enemy is a copycat and uses conditional love to manipulate, deceive, steal, and restrain our freedom by fear and

punishment to separate ourselves from God and His everlasting love for us. The great deceiver does this separation through masquerading as love, through conditions which influence our free will, deceiving our own subconscious into believing the properties of our own actions cause the conditional love. Forcing us through anxiety, shame, and guilt to subside with our own unforgiveness. Turning us away from the truth of God's loving which is unconditional. Stealing our fortitude, courage, respect, and dignity of our own self-love that we seem to never forgive ourselves but instead dwell in self-shame and guilt.

The enemy uses a wonderful gift from God. This gift that Jesus taught us was used to manipulate people. The experience of this gift that our Lord, our God has echoed throughout generations helping us and leading us towards God more, and more. The deception, by the great deceiver, was to forever condemn us. For even he believed his own lie and deception that he also condemned himself to everlasting eternal torment. However, the sovereign creator, omnipotent, alpha and omega allowed this understanding into exist so that His image barriers could reflect on how evil and good are so different in the hearts of those who follow Him. As he echoed earlier to Peter, in John, "... Follow me!"

Not all of us men may be familiar with the stories in the bible in which I am about to share. You do not have to be, but it is important to consider that to have a relationship with someone, getting to know who they are and where they come from is a step towards knowing how to love them more. Just like each one of us has experienced, not everyone cares about knowing who, why, or what has brought us to being who we are today. We all come with stories, dreams, hurts, and a past that we regret. This leads back to what many Christians call the 'Fall.'

For us that are not familiar, I will provide a soft summary but please understand the importance of your own deep dive into having a relationship with our Lord, and His story in our lives as what I am about to share highlights nothing compared to the beauty of leaning into Him through your own experiences of His words within you...

Story of Adam, Eve, and the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil

- God created Adam, the first man, and placed him in the Garden of Eden to work and take care of it (Genesis 2:15). God gave Adam freedom to eat from any tree in the garden except one: the tree of the knowledge of good and evil (Genesis 2:16-17). God commanded,
"You are free to eat from any tree in the garden; but you must not eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, for when you eat from it you will surely die."
- Eve was created from Adam's rib to be his companion (Genesis 2:21-22). The couple lived in innocence and nakedness without shame (Genesis 2:25).
- The serpent, crafty and deceptive, tempted Eve by questioning God's command and promising that eating the fruit would open their eyes and make them like God, knowing good and evil (Genesis 3:1-5).
- Eve ate the fruit from the tree of knowledge and gave some to Adam, who also ate it (Genesis 3:6).

- Their eyes were opened, they became aware of their nakedness, and they sewed fig leaves to cover themselves (Genesis 3:7).
- God confronted them, pronouncing consequences: pain in childbirth for the woman, cursed ground and painful toil for the man, and eventual physical death for both (Genesis 3:14-19).
- God expelled Adam and Eve from the Garden to prevent them from eating also from the tree of life and living forever in their fallen state (Genesis 3:22-24).

Key Scripture Passages

- "And the LORD God commanded the man, 'You are free to eat from any tree in the garden; but you must not eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, for when you eat of it you will certainly die.'" - Genesis 2:16-17
- "The serpent's temptation, Eve eating the fruit, and giving it to Adam."
– Genesis 3:1-6
- "Then the eyes of both of them were opened, and they knew that they were naked; so they sewed fig leaves together and made coverings for themselves."
– Genesis 3:7-8
- "God's curse and consequences for the serpent, woman, and man."
– Genesis 3:14-19
- "The banishment from Eden and the guarding of the tree of life."
– Genesis 3:22-24

Since the beginning of time God has always provided us with unconditional love. The purpose of the next piece is to allow us to be curious about this teaching between God and His creations. All three of them were created by God. All three are an important reflection upon not only from a theological perspective, but from an interpersonal as well as intrapersonal perspective. Taking in all parts of this teaching.

It was prior stated, called the "Fall," which references Genesis 3:22-24. We can then address Genesis 3:14-19 as the curse and consequences of the flesh for each of them to hold their own weight in what they did to take accountability for their own actions. The next part of God's design is where we want to be curious in this understanding of how to use a gift from God to replenish our unconditional love for others as He did with us. The key deliberational pieces are Awareness of Self-Love (Genesis 3:7-8), Temptation of Shame/Guilt (Genesis 3:1-6), and the root that Regret is Good (Genesis 2:16-17). The gift that God first gave us that the devil uses as a copycat is *regret*.

The key passages from Genesis 2–3 and their lessons show how regret can be used either by the devil to trap someone in endless shame and guilt, or by God to guide a person out of guilt and into self-forgiveness and love.

Key Scripture Passages

- "You are free to eat from any tree in the garden; but you must not eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, for when you eat of it you will certainly die." - Genesis 2:16-17
- "The serpent's temptation, Eve eating the fruit, and giving it to Adam." – Genesis 3:1-6
- "Then the eyes of both of them were opened, and they knew that they were naked; so they sewed fig leaves together and made coverings for themselves." - Genesis 3:7-8
- "God's curse and consequences for the serpent, woman, and man." – Genesis 3:14-19
- "The banishment from Eden and the guarding of the tree of life." – Genesis 3:22-24

How the Devil Uses Regret: The Spiral of Shame and Guilt

- The serpent (devil) tempts Adam and Eve to disobey God, promising false reward (Genesis 3:1-6).
- After sin, Adam and Eve feel immediate regret, which becomes shame ("they knew they were naked" – Genesis 3:7), and they try to hide their mistake rather than seek forgiveness.
- This shame leads to guilt and the sense of being "not good enough" for God or His love.
- The spiral continues: shame triggers more regret, regret feeds more guilt, which deepens self-condemnation ("I am bad, I am not worthy").
- Instead of finding freedom, a person remains stuck in endless cycles: regret → shame → guilt → self-condemnation → deeper regret and shame.
- The devil is called the "great deceiver" because he mimics God's gift of regret, using it not to restore but to imprison a person in hopelessness, preventing them from seeking forgiveness or genuine change.

How God Uses Regret: The Pathway to Self-Forgiveness and Love

- God allows regret as a gift—it stirs the conscience after harmful choices (Genesis 3:7-8).
- That initial regret, if brought to God, leads a person to acknowledge their actions and feel healthy sorrow for what was wrong ("godly sorrow brings repentance" – principle shown in Genesis and throughout scripture).
- This sorrow is meant to guide the person to repent—turn away from the mistake and seek God's everlasting love and forgiveness.
- God's forgiveness breaks the spiral: instead of hiding, a person confesses, receives grace, and begins self-forgiveness.
- Self-forgiveness opens the way to self-love and compassion, as the person now sees themselves as loved and restored by God.
- This journey honors the purpose of regret: not to keep us bound, but to bring us out of shame and guilt, into newness and relationship with God.

Contrast Table: The Devil's Spiral vs. God's Pathway

	The Devil's Spiral (Deception)	God's Pathway (Restoration)
Trigger	Regret after sin	Regret after sin
Step 1	Shame ("I am bad")	Healthy regret ("I did wrong")
Step 2	Regret feeds guilt	Shame/guilt move person to repentance
Step 3	Guilt deepens into self-condemnation	Person turns to God, receives forgiveness
Step 4	Self-condemnation leads to more shame/regret	Forgiveness leads to self-forgiveness
Step 5	Feels unworthy of love, trapped in cycle	Self-forgiveness leads to self-love/compassion
Result	Endless loop; isolation and despair	Freedom and wholeness in God's love

Summary

The devil twists the gift of regret to trap individuals in endless self-criticism, shame, and guilt—never allowing them to accept forgiveness or experience love.

God, by contrast, uses regret as a starting point for honest repentance, leading through forgiveness to self-love and restored relationship. Freedom comes by recognizing God's purpose for regret and choosing to step out of the devil's spiral through repentance and grace.

Introduction

Many men have learned to love through conditions, shaped by parents, culture, and mentors who—often unconsciously—used regret or disappointment as tools for behavior correction. Sometimes, these patterns reflect a cycle of regret, shame, and self-condemnation that echoes the enemy’s tactics more than God’s loving design. This workbook helps men confront these cycles, discover God’s pathway of regret to restoration, and step into their true calling as image bearers of unconditional love.

Section 1: Recognizing Conditional vs. Unconditional Love

Reflection Questions:

- How do I show love to those around me?

“Beloved, let us love one another, for love is from God, and everyone who loves is born of God and knows God.” – 1 John 4:7 (KJV)

- How do I withdraw love or affection when I am disappointed or hurt by someone’s actions?

“Love bears all things, believes all things, hopes all things, endures all things.” – 1 Corinthians 13:7 (KJV)

- What are some ways I have learned (from parents, family, church, coaches, mentors) that love must be “earned”?

“For by grace are ye saved through faith; and that not of yourselves: it is the gift of God.” – Ephesians 2:8 (KJV)

- Think of a recent conflict: Did I offer love freely, or was my love present only if the other person met my expectations?

[illegible]

“A new command I give you: Love one another. As I have loved you, so you must love one another.” – John 13:34 (TPT)

- Describe what unconditional love would look like in my family, friendships, marriage, or community.

[illegible]

“May the Lord make your love increase and overflow for each other and for everyone else.” – 1 Thessalonians 3:12 (KJV)

Section 2: Tracing the Roots—How Regret Has Been Used in Your Life

Reflection Questions:

- Growing up, how was regret or remorse overseen in my home?

“Children, obey your parents in the Lord: for this is right.” – Ephesians 6:1 (KJV)

- Was I encouraged to admit mistakes, or was I shamed, scolded, or made to “pay” for them?

“If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins.” – 1 John 1:9 (KJV)

- Were there repeating words or actions (from parents, mentors, or leaders) that made me feel stuck in cycles of shame or “not good enough”?

“There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus.” – Romans 8:1 (KJV)

- What cycles do I notice in myself when I mess up (regret → shame → guilt → self-condemnation → more regret...)? Write or diagram what this looks like for you.

“For the Spirit renews my heart and sets me free to live in God’s victory.” – Romans 8:2 (TPT)

Section 3: Identifying the Devil's Spiral vs. God's Pathway

The Devil's Spiral	God's Pathway
Regret after a mistake	Regret after a mistake
Shame ("I am bad")	Healthy regret ("I did wrong")
Guilt, leading to self-condemnation	Honest sorrow leads to repentance
Hidden, isolated, more regret and shame	Repentance leads to forgiveness
Feels unworthy of love, stuck in cycle	Forgiveness opens door to self-compassion

Reflection Questions:

- How do I react to my own mistakes—do I hide, avoid, blame, or condemn myself?

"Come now, and let us reason together, saith the LORD: though your sins be as scarlet, they shall be as white as snow." – Isaiah 1:18 (KJV)

- How do I react to the mistakes of others—do I use words, silence, or actions that make them feel trapped, or do I help them seek restoration?

“Therefore, if thou bring thy gift to the altar, and there rememberest that thy brother hath ought against thee; leave there thy gift before the altar, and go thy way; first be reconciled to thy brother.” – Matthew 5:23-24 (KJV)

- See yourself stuck in the Devil’s cycle? In what relationships can you visualize this cycle in which you feel stuck in?

“Forgetting those things which are behind, and reaching forth unto those things which are before.” – Philippians 3:13 (KJV)

Self-Examination:

- When I feel regret, what is the next emotion or thought? Do I feel shame, guilt, or condemnation afterward? Do I get stuck? List what you notice.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

2. Interrupt the Cycle: **TAKE ACTION**

“Though he fall, he shall not be utterly cast down: for the LORD upholdeth him with his hand.” – Psalm 37:24 (KJV)

3. Practice Confession and Repentance:

- Write out one regret I have hidden from God or others.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart: try me, and know my thoughts:” – Psalm 139:23 (KJV)

- Speak it in prayer and write the prayer down; ask for God’s forgiveness and direction. Write down your prayer

4. Embrace Grace:

- If God forgives me, can I take a step toward forgiving myself? What is that? How am I going to walk that?

“I have loved thee with an everlasting love: therefore with lovingkindness have I drawn thee.” – Jeremiah 31:3 (KJV)

- What truth does God say about me as His Beloved?

"See what great love the Father has lavished on us, that we should be called children of God! And that is what we are!" – 1 John 3:1 (NIV)

5. Self-Compassion and Compassion for Others:

- How can I show myself the kindness I would give to a loved one?

"Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as God in Christ forgave you." – Ephesians 4:32 (TPT)

- How can I help others break out of their own shame cycles?

"Bear ye one another's burdens, and so fulfil the law of Christ." – Galatians 6:2 (KJV)

Section 5: Questions for Loving Others Unconditionally

Reflection Questions:

- When someone hurts or disappoints me, how do I withdraw my love or support and what made me do this?

“Love worketh no ill to his neighbour: therefore love is the fulfilling of the law.” – Romans 13:10 (KJV)

- What would it look like for me to “love without conditions” in challenging situations?

“Be ye therefore merciful, as your Father also is merciful.” – Luke 6:36 (KJV)

- When I ever shame others in my family, work, or community when they make mistakes, how can I respond in a way that points them toward hope and restoration?

“My brothers and sisters, if one of you should wander from the truth and someone should bring that person back,” – James 5:19 (NIV)

- Am I willing to say, “I forgive you,” and mean it—even if the other person does not change right away? What makes this hard?

“Be ye kind one to another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, even as God for Christ's sake hath forgiven you.” – Ephesians 4:32 (KJV)

- How often do I use regret to keep others in my life in a cycle of self-criticism, instead of guiding them toward healing and growth? Give yourself examples.

“Let all bitterness, and wrath, and anger, and clamour, and evil speaking, be put away from you, with all malice:” – Ephesians 4:31 (KJV)

Section 6: Becoming an Image Bearer—Walking in Unconditional Love

Action Steps:

- Daily Practice: Begin each day by asking, “How can I love those in my life the way God loves me—without condition?” List by name, and action step without condition.

“This is my commandment, That ye love one another, as I have loved you.” – John 15:12 (KJV)

- Community Accountability: Find a friend or group to share honestly about these journeys—help each other notice and escape the devil’s regret cycles. List group(s).

“Where no counsel is, the people fall: but in the multitude of counsellors there is safety.” – Proverbs 11:14 (KJV)

- Prayer Prompt: “Father, help me see myself and others as Your Beloved. Teach me Your ways of compassion and grace. Let my love reflect who You are, not the patterns of the past.” Self-reflect what is coming up in you.

“Create in me a clean heart, O God; and renew a right spirit within me.” – Psalm 51:10 (KJV)

Section 7: Final Reflection and Commitment

- What is one old regret I am ready to bring to God for healing?

“He healeth the broken in heart, and bindeth up their wounds.” – Psalm 147:3 (KJV)

- What is one relationship in which I want to practice unconditional love this week?
How am I going to act in this, list steps.

“Let all that you do be done in love.” – 1 Corinthians 16:14 (KJV)

- How will I encourage other men to walk with God’s design for regret and love rather than the enemy’s counterfeit cycle? In the next 12 months, list one step each month that you will act on to help other men walk out of their own regret and into self-compassion and forgiveness.

“Therefore encourage one another and build each other up.” – 1 Thessalonians 5:11 (NIV)

Remember

God's purpose for regret is to turn us from shame and self-condemnation toward restoration, forgiveness, and new life. As men, walking as sons of God means helping ourselves and others out of the enemy's spiral—so we might genuinely love, forgive, and have compassion as God's Beloved image bearers.